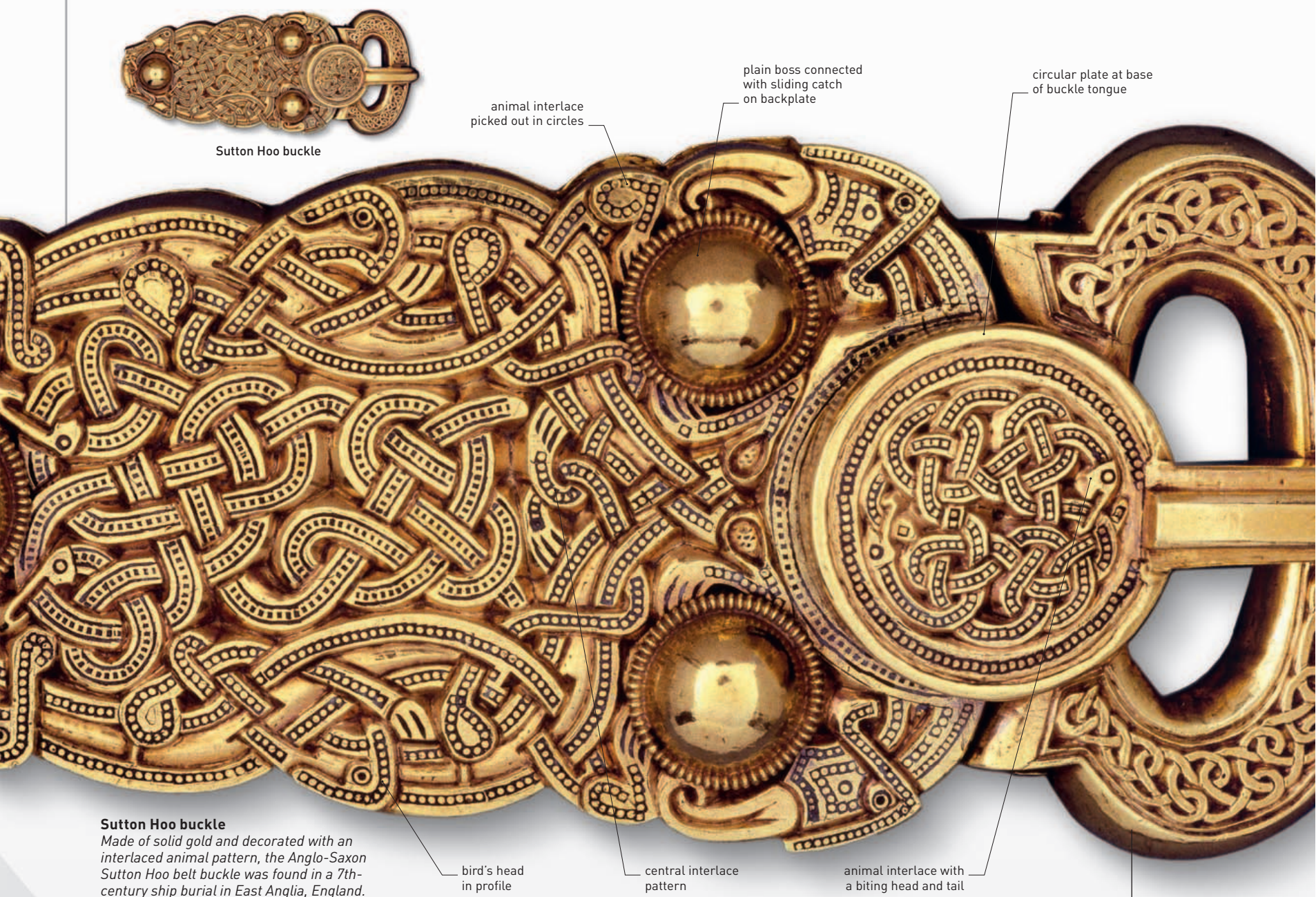




Sutton Hoo buckle

Made of solid gold and decorated with an interlaced animal pattern, the Anglo-Saxon Sutton Hoo belt buckle was found in a 7th-century ship burial in East Anglia, England.

Prehistory

Use of copper ore

In western Iran and Anatolia, copper ore is ground or beaten into shape to make small objects such as beads.



Copper ore

c. 1500–1200 BCE

Refinement of bronze casting

New techniques are developed for casting and adorning bronze vessels, such as decorating them by beating on the inside.



Shang cauldron

c. 900 BCE–100 CE

Using iron

Ironworking spreads from western Anatolia, reaching Greece around 900 BCE and West Africa about 400 BCE, enabling stronger tools and weapons to be made.



Weapon heads

c. 100–700

Anglo-Saxon metalworking

The Anglo-Saxons bring a new level of sophistication to metalworking, often using animal forms as decoration.

2600–2400 BCE

Use of beaten copper plate

Early copper smelting methods are refined, allowing the beating of copper while still hot into more complex shapes.



Sumerian copper bull

c. 1500–30 BCE

Purifying gold

The ancient Egyptians learn how to separate pure gold from silver in around 1500 BCE and begin to use it more extensively for decorative purposes.

Funeral mask of Tutankhamun



c. 640–500 BCE

Metal as money

Metal coins (made of an alloy of gold and silver) are first used in Lydia (in present-day Turkey) around 640 BCE. The ancient Greeks adopt the idea and spread it around the Mediterranean.



Greek coin